BSU-IACUC Web Portal User Manual

For Principal Investigators/Researchers

Benguet State University, Cordillera Center for Animal Research and Development (CCARD)

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I. About this manual

This manual explains how to use the BSU-IACUC portal as a researcher. It follows the order in which most people use the system: creating an account, submitting a protocol, answering reviewer comments, paying the clearance fee, and getting the clearance.

The portal is run by the Institutional Animal Care and Use Committee (IACUC) under CCARD. A protocol is the written plan, filled out on the official IACUC form, that describes how you will use live animals in your research. IACUC review is needed for work that involves direct interaction with live animals. Work that uses only animals or tissue that were already dead does not need a protocol.

II. Before you start

Prepare the following before you open the application form.

1. An email address you can open right now. The portal sends a verification link to it and uses it for every status update.
2. A Philippine mobile number. CCARD staff may call you about your protocol.
3. Your IACUC training certificate, as a PDF, JPG or PNG file of 10 MB or less. This is only needed for your first submission. The certificate comes from the IACUC course or seminar on animal care and use. If you have not taken it yet, contact CCARD for a schedule before applying.
4. The official IACUC protocol form, filled out completely. You can download it inside the application (see section VI).

Only the Principal Investigator may submit a protocol. If you work in a group, one person submits for everyone. Submitting the same protocol more than once will get it rejected.

The portal works in any current browser on a computer, tablet or phone.

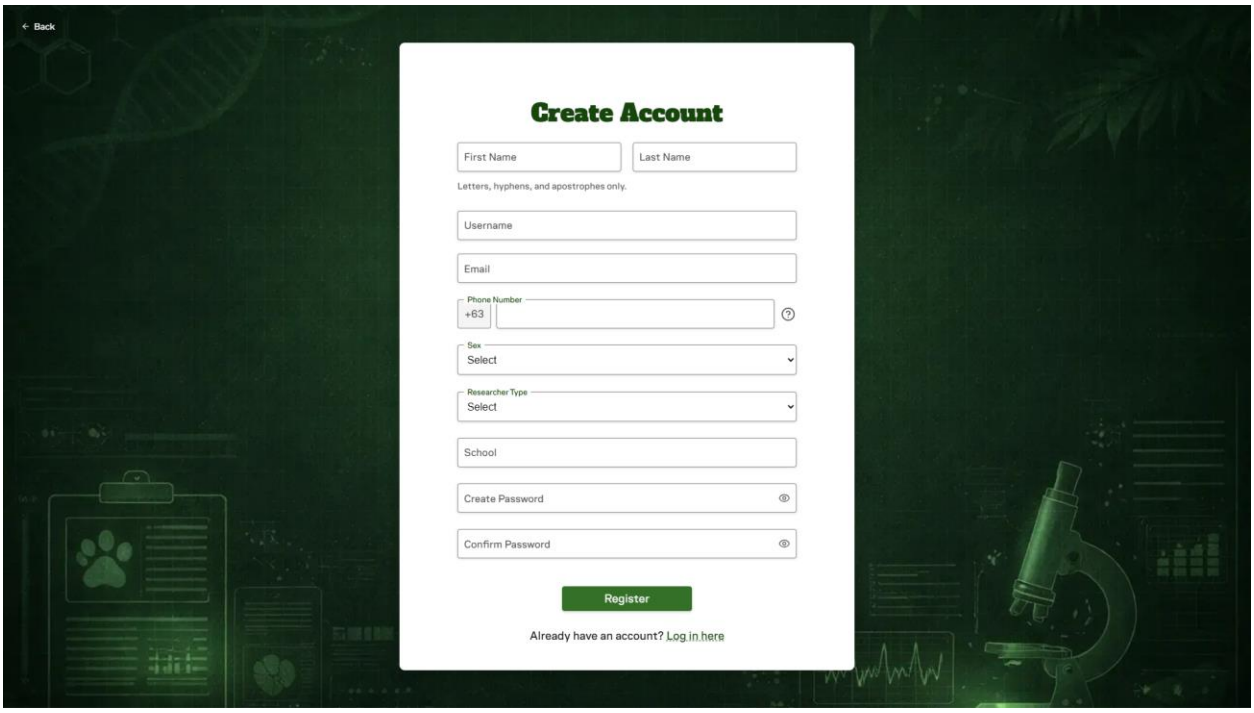
III. Creating an account

1. Open the portal home page and press Register in the top bar.
2. Fill in the form. Every field is required.

Field	***What to enter***
First name, Last name	Letters, spaces, hyphens and apostrophes only, at least 2 characters each
Username	3 to 50 characters. Letters, numbers, underscores and hyphens only
Email	A valid address you can open

Phone number	Philippine mobile number, for example +639171234567
Sex	Male or Female
Researcher type	Student, Faculty, Staff or Researcher
School	Pick your school or college from the list
Password	At least 8 characters, with an uppercase letter, a lowercase letter, a number and a special character (! @ # $ % ^ & *)

3. Press Register.



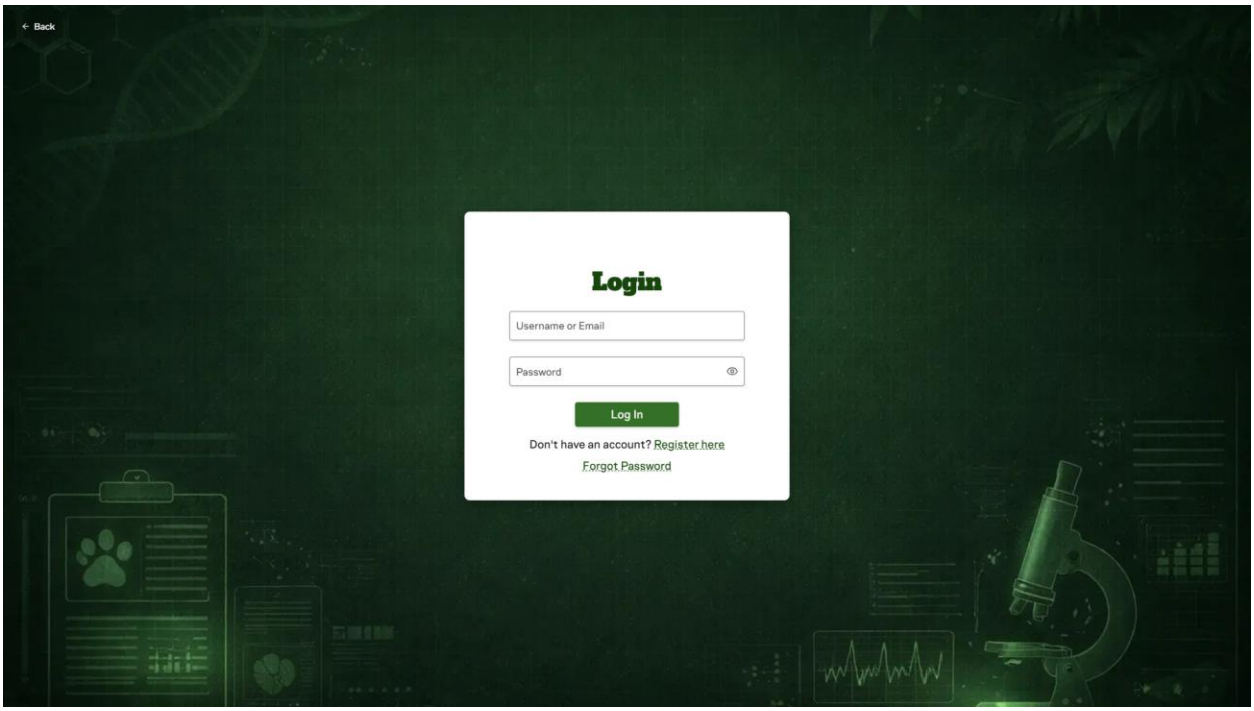
Verifying your email

After registering, the portal sends a verification link to your email. Open the link to confirm the address. You cannot log in until this is done.

If the email does not arrive, check your spam folder. You can also go to the login page, enter your email in the verification box and press Send Verification Link to get a new one.

IV. Logging in and out

On the login page, enter your username or email and your password, then press Log In. After a successful login you land on My Protocols.



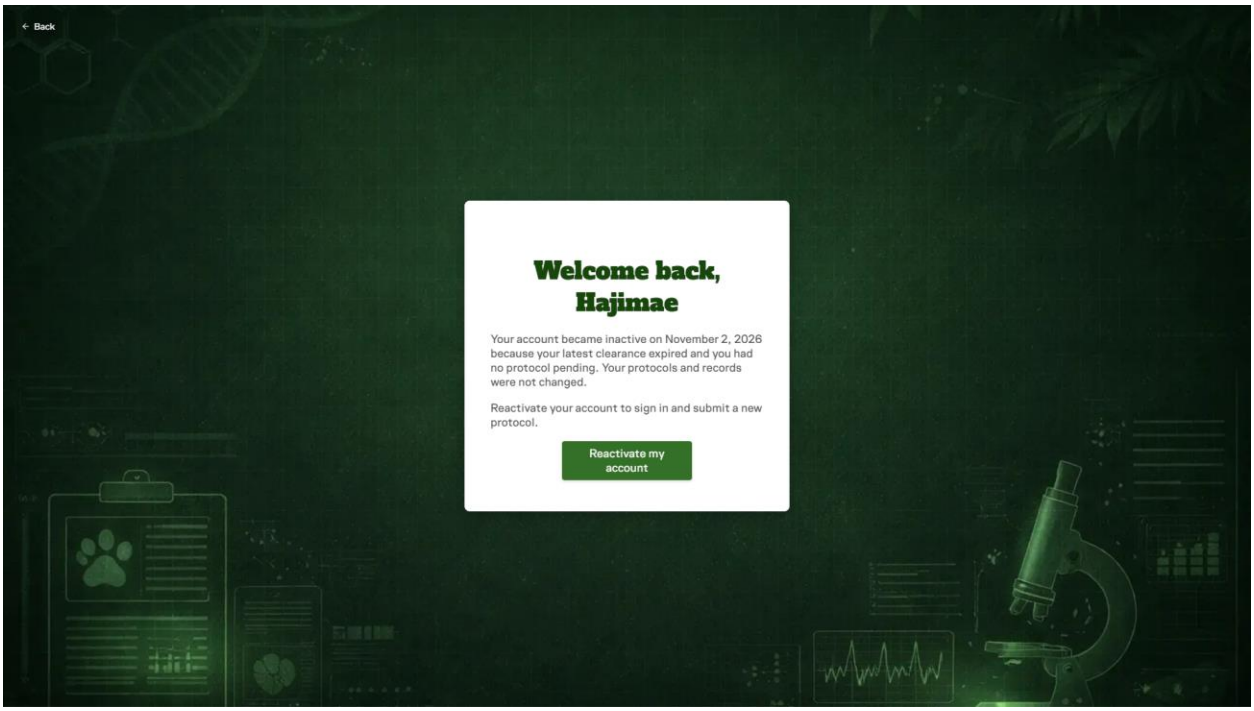
A few things to know:

- Five wrong attempts within 15 minutes lock the login for 15 minutes. Wait, then try again.
- If you forget your password, press Forgot Password, enter your email and open the reset link we send. Choose a new password that meets the same rules as above. If the link has expired, request a new one from the same page.
- For your protection, the portal signs you out after 30 minutes without activity. A warning appears about two minutes before this happens. Press the button in the warning to stay signed in.
- Log out from the account menu at the top right when you are using a shared computer.

Inactive accounts

Your account becomes inactive when your animal research clearance has ended and none of your protocols are still being processed. Your protocols and records are kept. To come back, log in and press Reactivate my account on the screen that appears. Everything is as you left it.

If CCARD staff deactivated your account, you cannot reactivate it yourself. Contact CCARD.



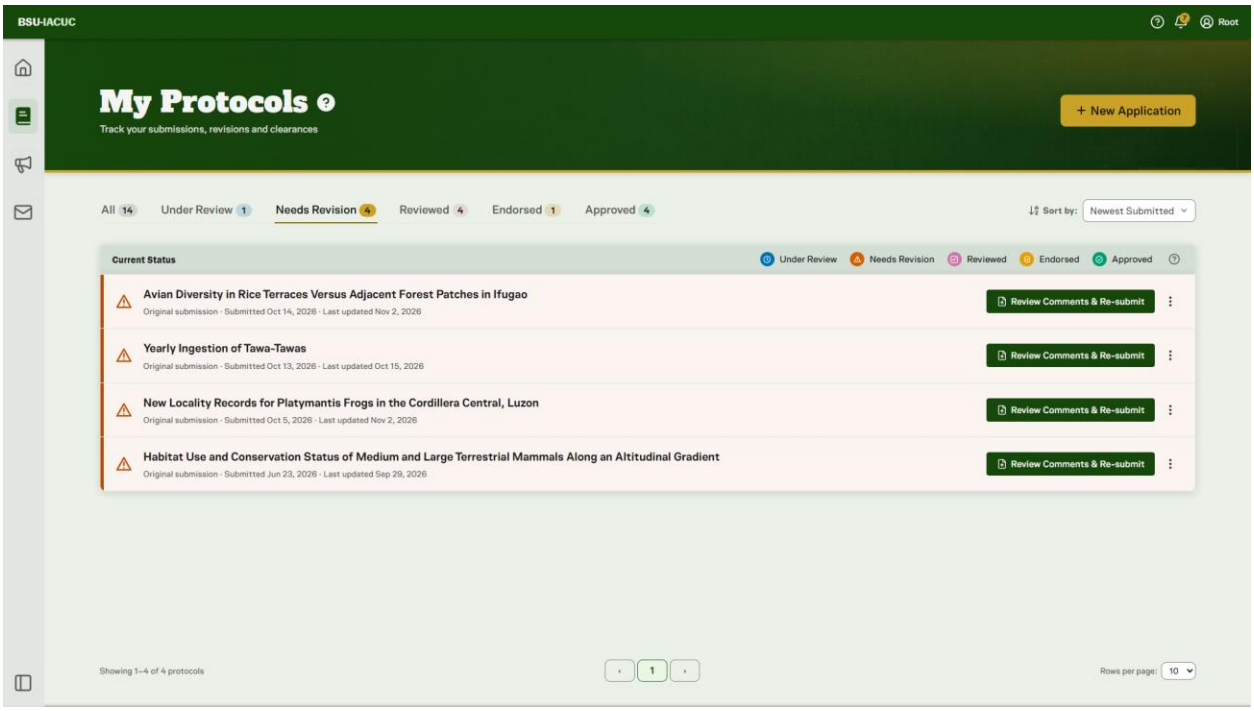
V. Finding your way around

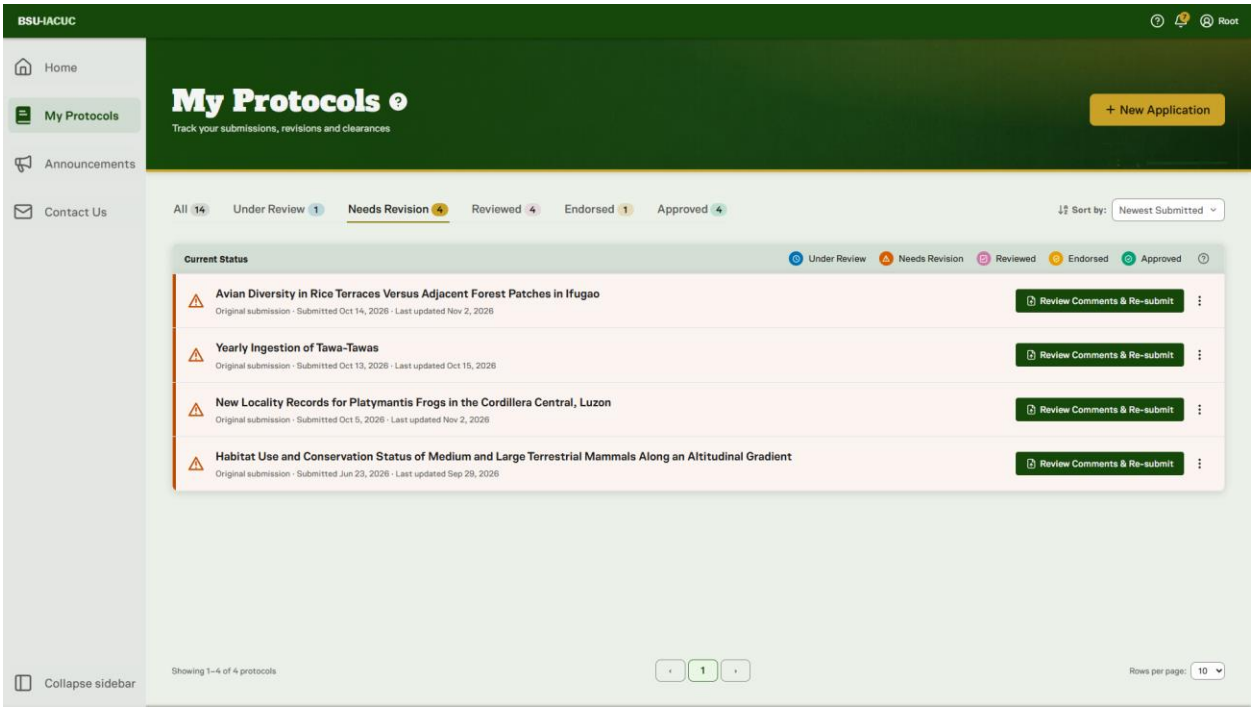
The menu

The icon bar on the left side of the page (the menu button on a phone) has four pages.

Page	*What it is for*
Home	What IACUC is, how to apply, and frequently asked questions
My Protocols	Your applications. This is where you will spend most of your time
Announcements	News and training schedules from CCARD
Contact Us	How to reach CCARD and the other offices involved

Press the Expand sidebar button at the bottom of the bar to show the page names next to the icons.





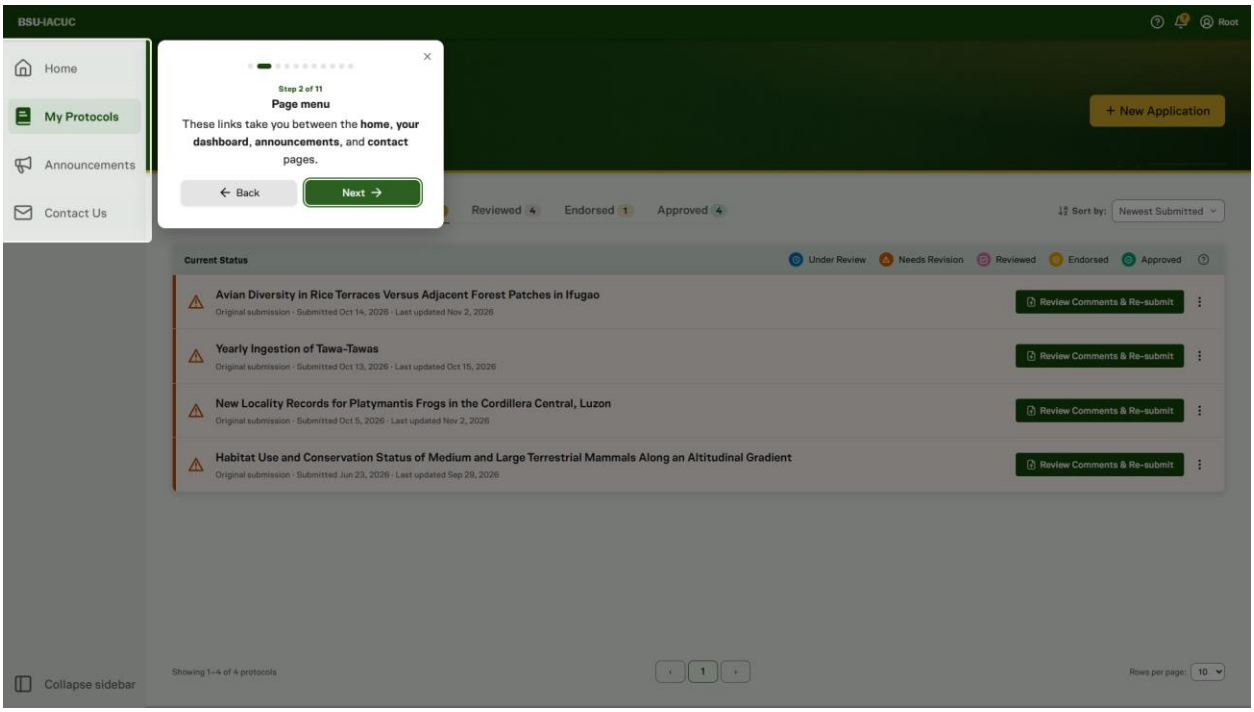
The top bar

The top bar holds the Guide button, the notification bell, and My Account. A small Offline tag appears beside the logo when your device has lost its connection (see section XIII).



Built-in guides

The portal can walk you through itself. The first time you log in, a short tour starts automatically. Press the Guide button in the top bar to replay it. Most pages also have a small question mark button next to the page title that opens a tour of that page. Use Next and Back to move through a tour, or press Enter to go forward.

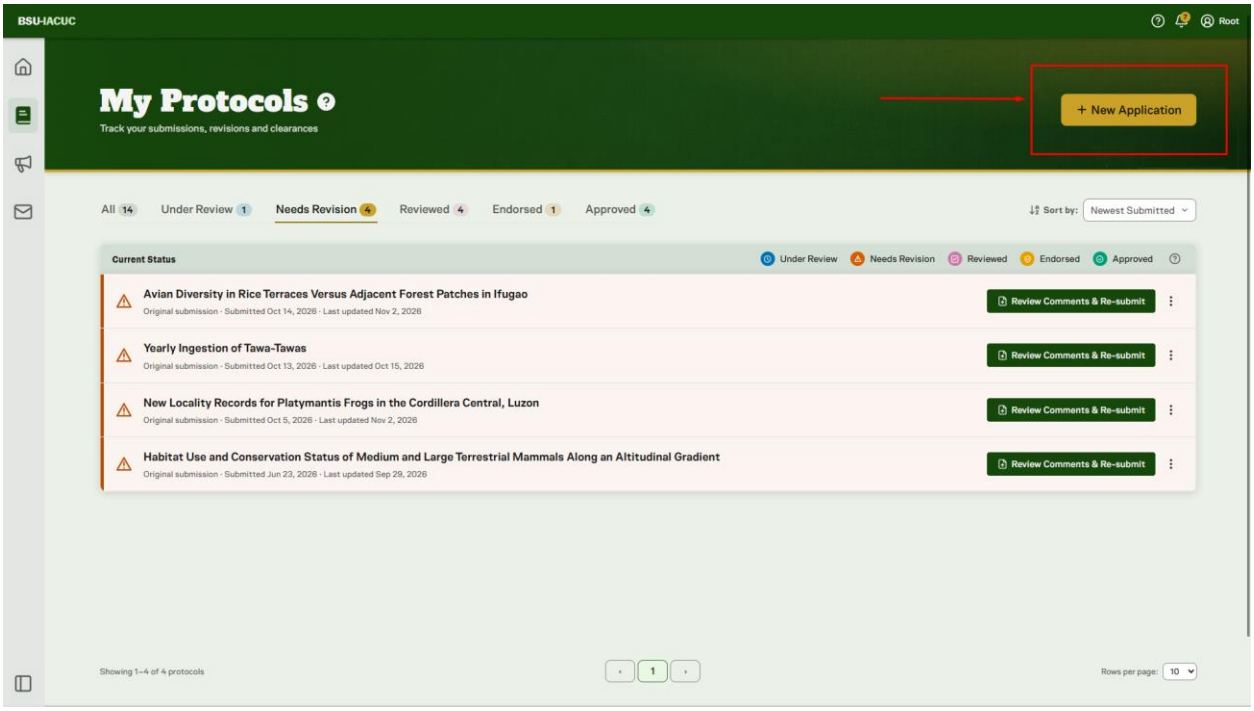


Light and dark theme

Open My Account and choose light, dark or system. System follows your device setting.

VI. Applying for protocol review

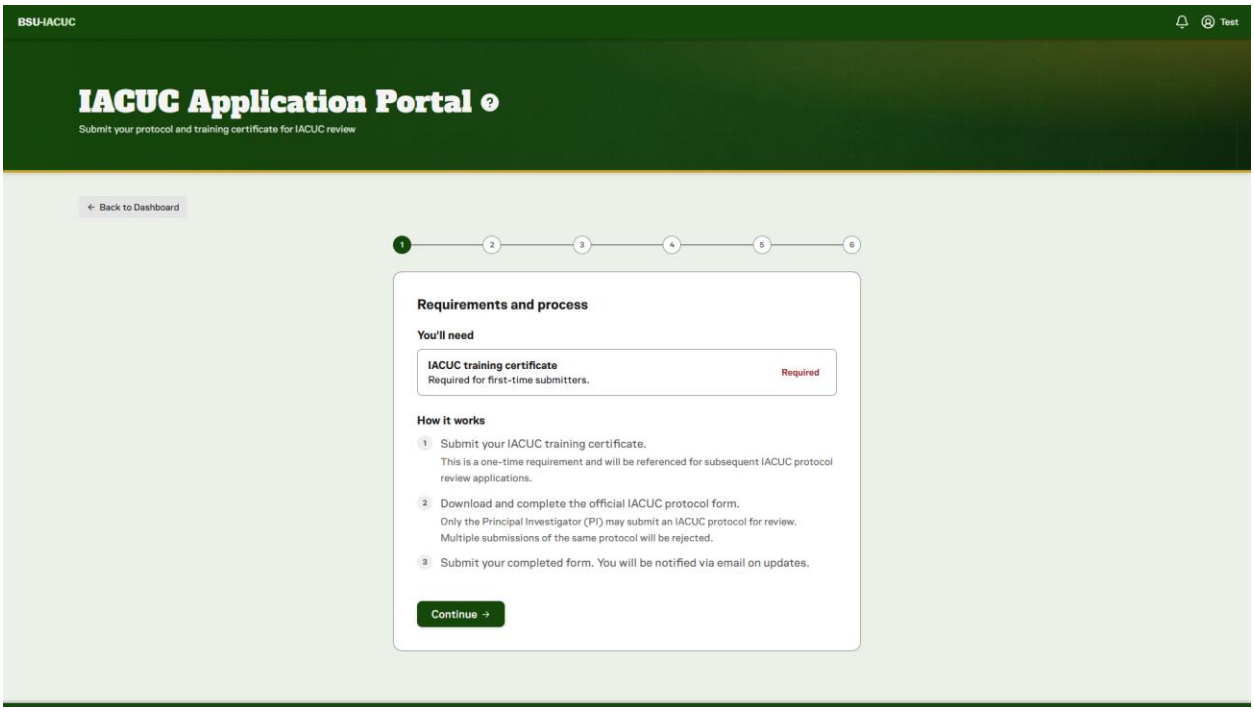
On My Protocols, press New Application. The application has up to six steps, and a numbered bar at the top shows where you are. Use Back and Continue to move between steps.



Step 1: Requirements

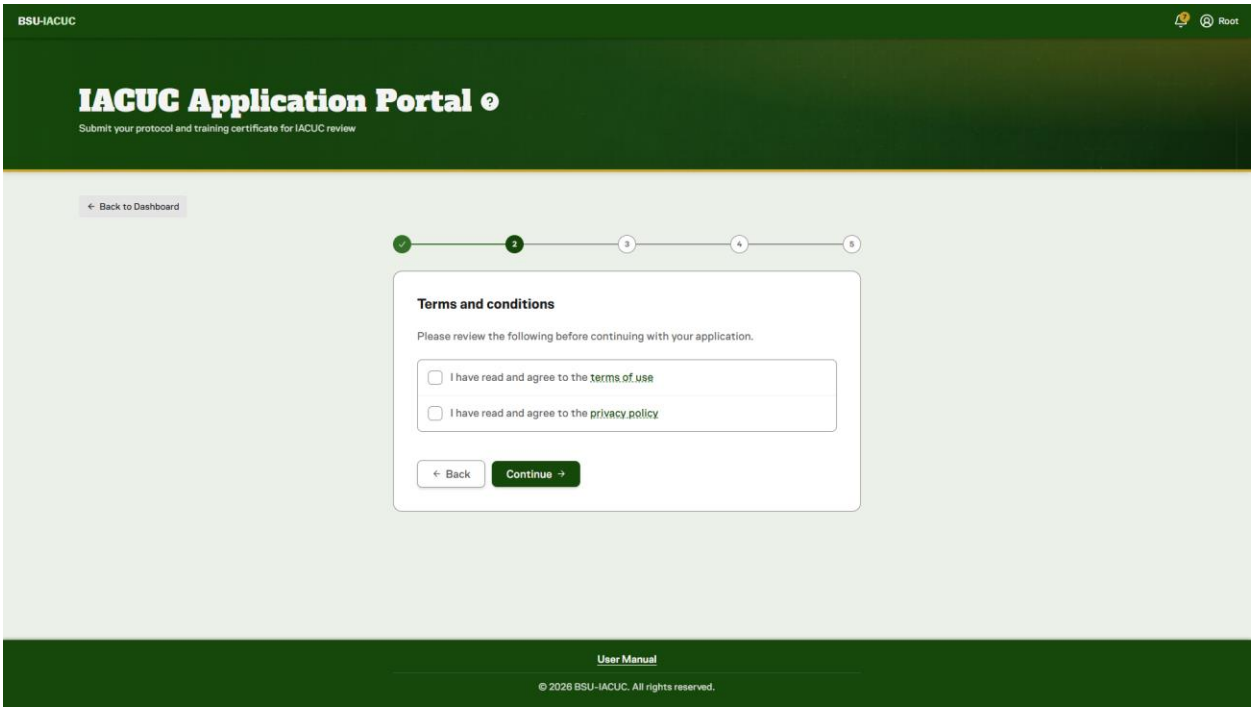
This page shows what you need and how the process works. It also shows the state of your IACUC training certificate: Required if you have never submitted one, Pending while CCARD checks it, Verified once accepted, or Resubmit if it was rejected.

If your certificate was rejected, you cannot submit a new protocol until you upload a new one from My Account.



Step 2: Terms and conditions

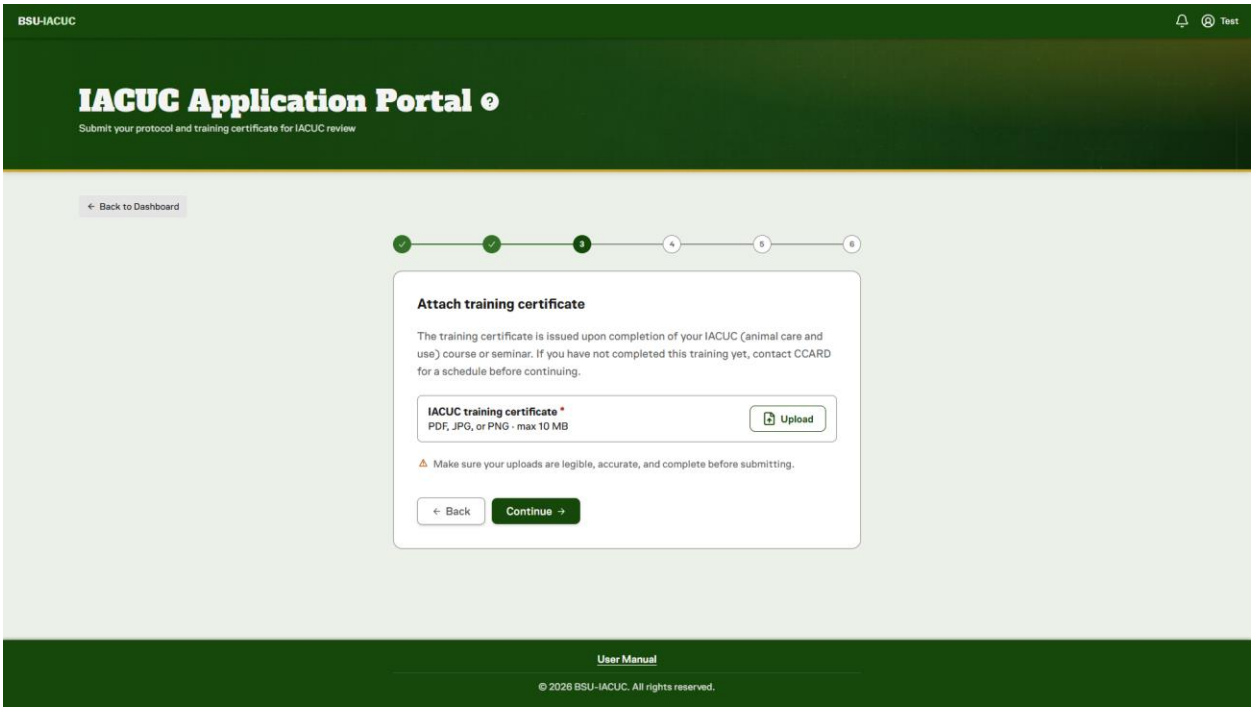
Read the terms of use and the privacy policy by pressing their links. Tick both boxes to agree, then continue. You cannot move on without agreeing to both.



Step 3: Training certificate

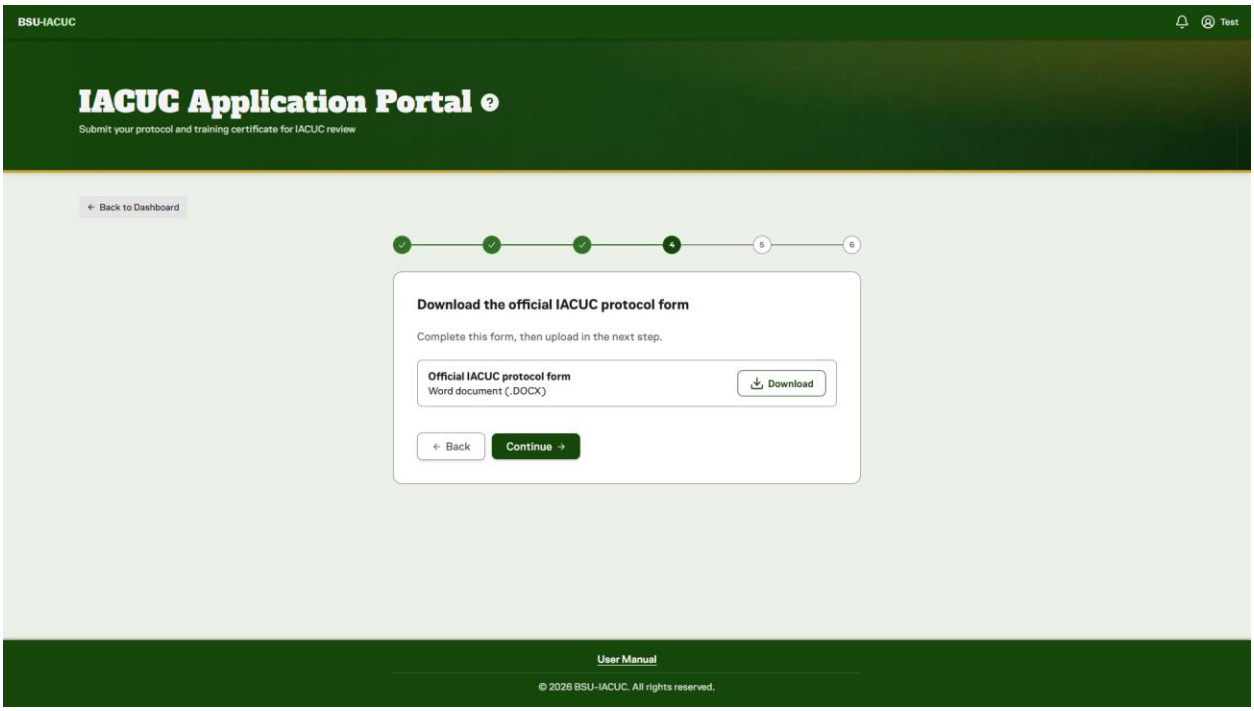
Upload your IACUC training certificate (PDF, JPG or PNG, up to 10 MB). Make sure it is readable and complete.

This step is skipped if you already have a certificate on file. The certificate is a one-time requirement and is reused for your later protocols.



Step 4: Download the form

Press Download to get the official IACUC protocol form as a Word file. Fill it out, print it, collect the required signatures, and scan the signed copy.



Step 5: Upload and submit

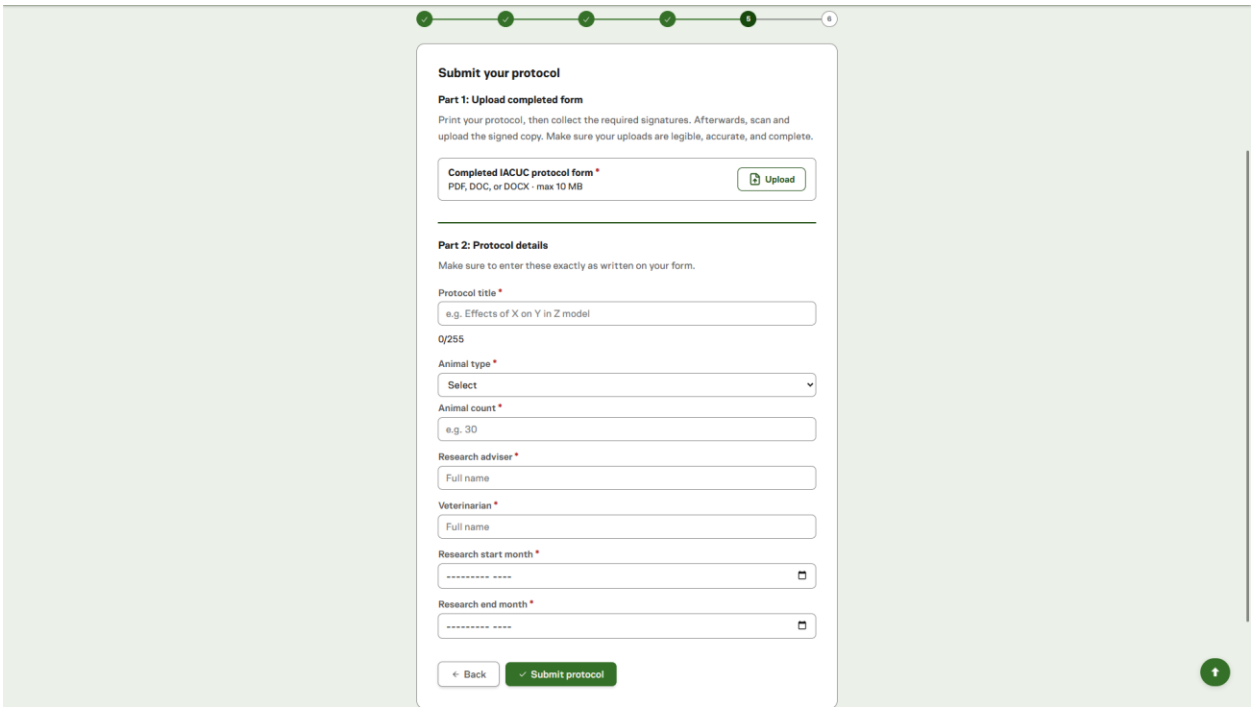
This step has two parts.

Part 1: upload the signed protocol form. PDF, DOC and DOCX files up to 10 MB are accepted. Word files are converted to PDF, so open the converted file with Preview and check that the layout still looks right.

Part 2: enter the protocol details. Type them exactly as they appear on your form.

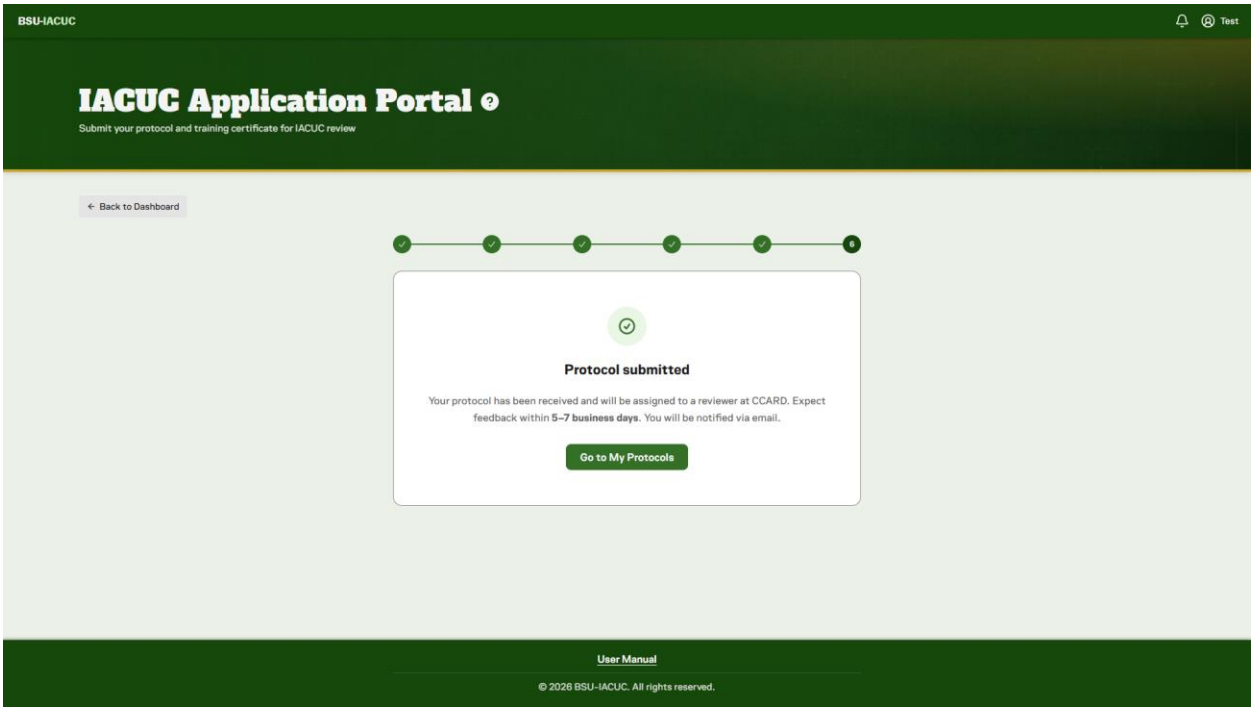
Field	***Notes***
Protocol title	Up to 255 characters
Animal type	Pick from the list
Animal count	A whole number of 1 or more
Research adviser	Full name
Veterinarian	Full name
Research start month	Month and year
Research end month	Cannot be earlier than the start month

All fields are required. The adviser and veterinarian are filled in from your previous protocol when there is one. Press Submit protocol when everything is ready.



Step 6: Done

A confirmation page appears. Your protocol goes to a reviewer at CCARD, and you can expect feedback within 5 to 7 business days. You will be notified by email.

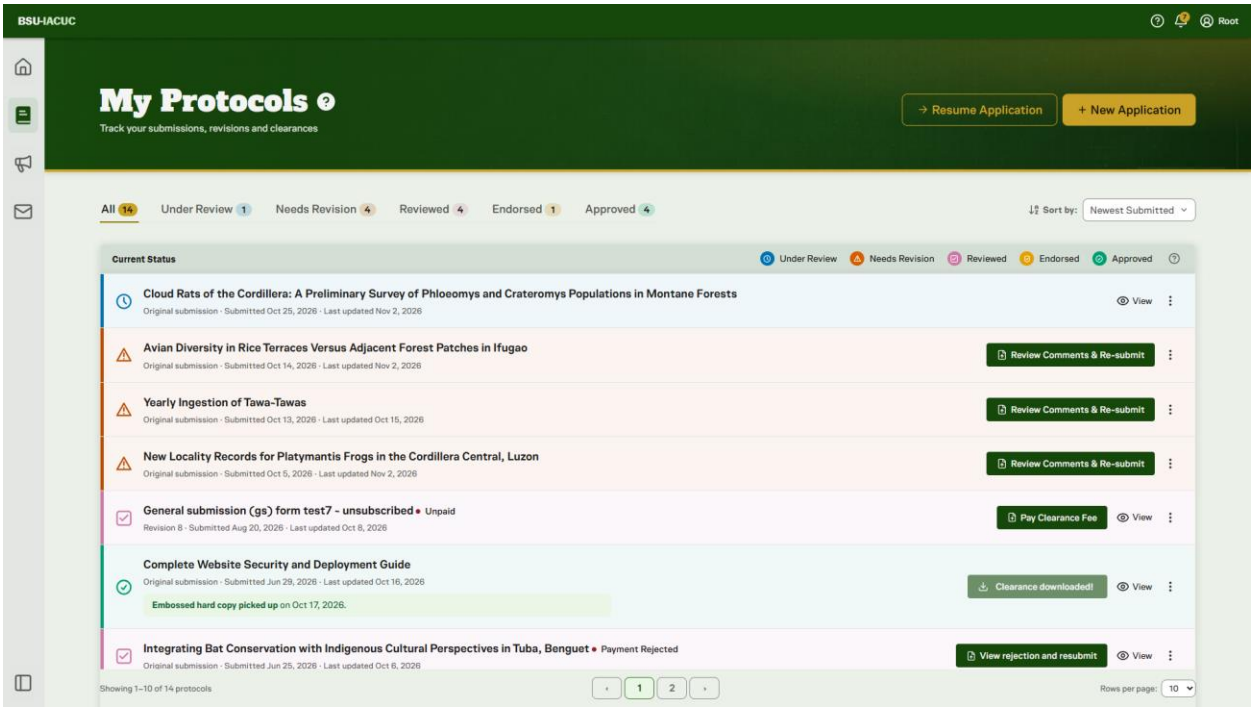


Leaving and resuming

Your progress is saved as you go. Press Back to Dashboard at any time to leave, and confirm. When you come back, press Resume on My Protocols and you will continue where you stopped.

VII. My Protocols

My Protocols lists every protocol you have submitted.



- Status filters at the top narrow the list to one status. The number beside each name is how many of your protocols have that status.
- Sort changes the order: newest or oldest submitted, recently updated, or by title.
- The status legend shows the color and icon of each status. Press the question mark at the end of the bar to read what each status means.
- Each card is one protocol. It shows the status icon, the title, the submission round, the date submitted and the date last updated.
- The bar at the bottom lets you move between pages and choose 10, 25 or 50 protocols per page.

On each card, the main button changes with the status, and View opens the protocol. The three-dot menu holds the other actions (section XI).

VIII. What each status means

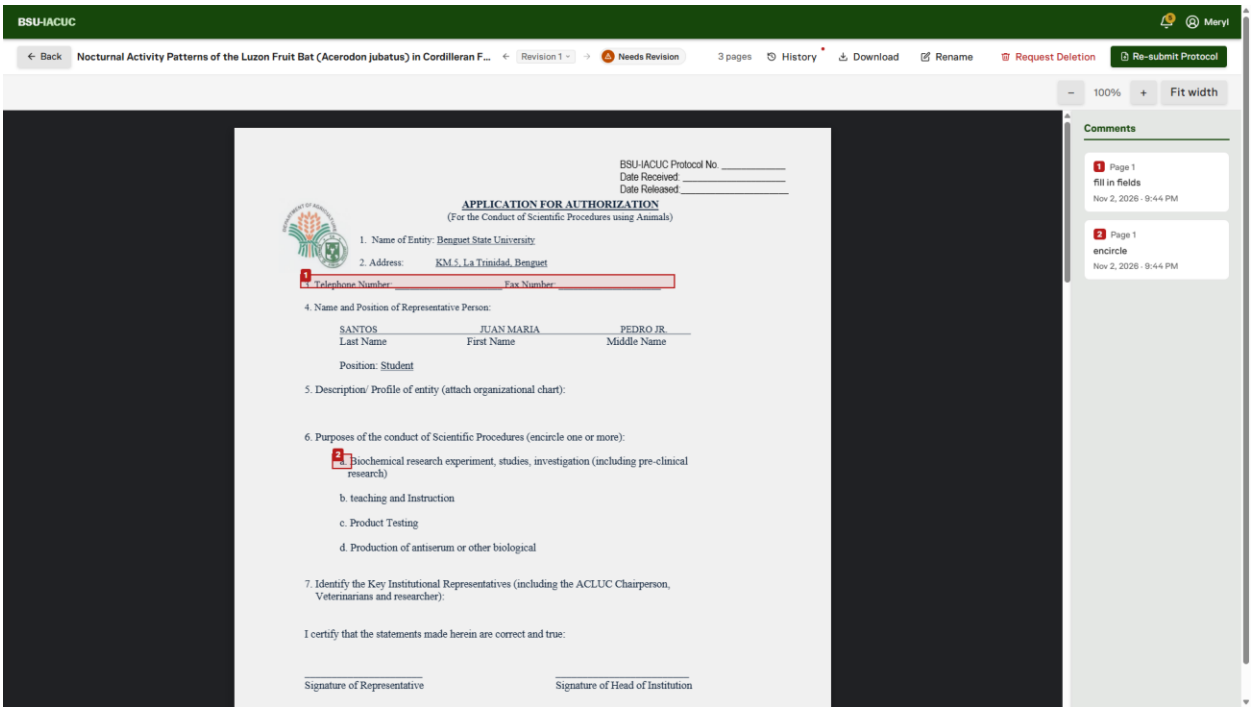
Status	*What it means*	*What you do*
Under Review	Your protocol, and your training certificate if it is your first, are being reviewed.	Wait. You are notified of every feedback. Your protocol will not move forward unless your certificate is verified. If the certificate is rejected, resubmit it.
Needs Revision	The reviewer found an issue and sent the protocol back.	Open it, read the comments, fix your file and re-submit (section IX).
Reviewed	Your protocol passed review.	Pay the clearance fee (section X). After CCARD verifies your payment, wait for the protocol to be endorsed.
Endorsed	CCARD endorsed your protocol to the Department of Agriculture, Regional Field Office, Cordillera Administrative Region (DA-RFO-CAR). The Bureau of Animal Industry (BAI) Central Office is processing your clearance.	Nothing. Wait for the next update.
Approved	Your animal research clearance has been issued.	Download the soft copy and pick up the embossed copy at CCARD (section XII).

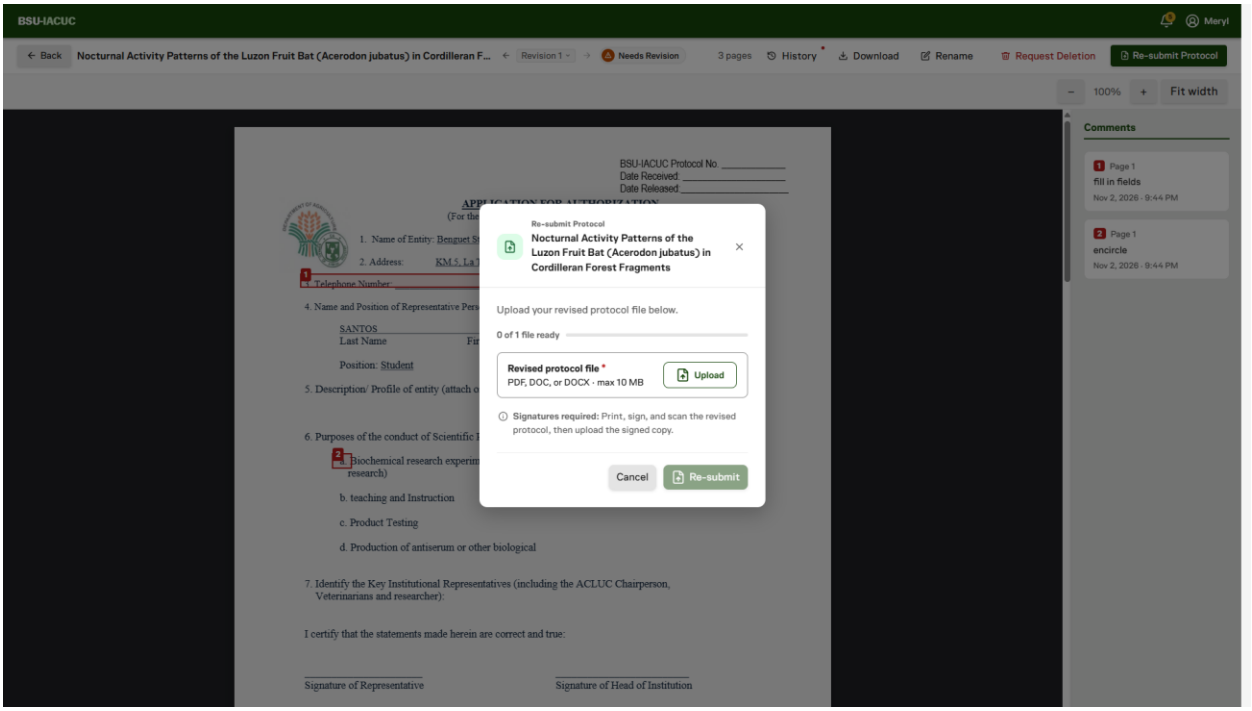
IX. Revising and re-submitting

When a protocol is sent back, its card says Needs Revision and shows a note from CCARD, which may list the issues found and a comment from the reviewer. You also get a notification and an email.

1. Press Review Comments and Re-submit on the card.
2. The protocol opens in the viewer. Reviewer comments appear as boxes drawn on the document, and the Comments panel lists them. Comments only become visible to you after the protocol has been returned.
3. Make the changes in your form. Print it, sign it and scan it as before.
4. Press Re-submit Protocol, choose the revised file, and press Re-submit.

The protocol goes back to Under Review. Each round is counted, so you will see labels for first submission and for each re-submission in the version history.





If your training certificate is rejected

Your review is on hold. Press Resubmit Certificate on My Protocols or inside the protocol, and upload a new certificate (PDF, JPG or PNG, up to 10 MB). The review continues once it is verified. A note from the reviewer explains why it was rejected.

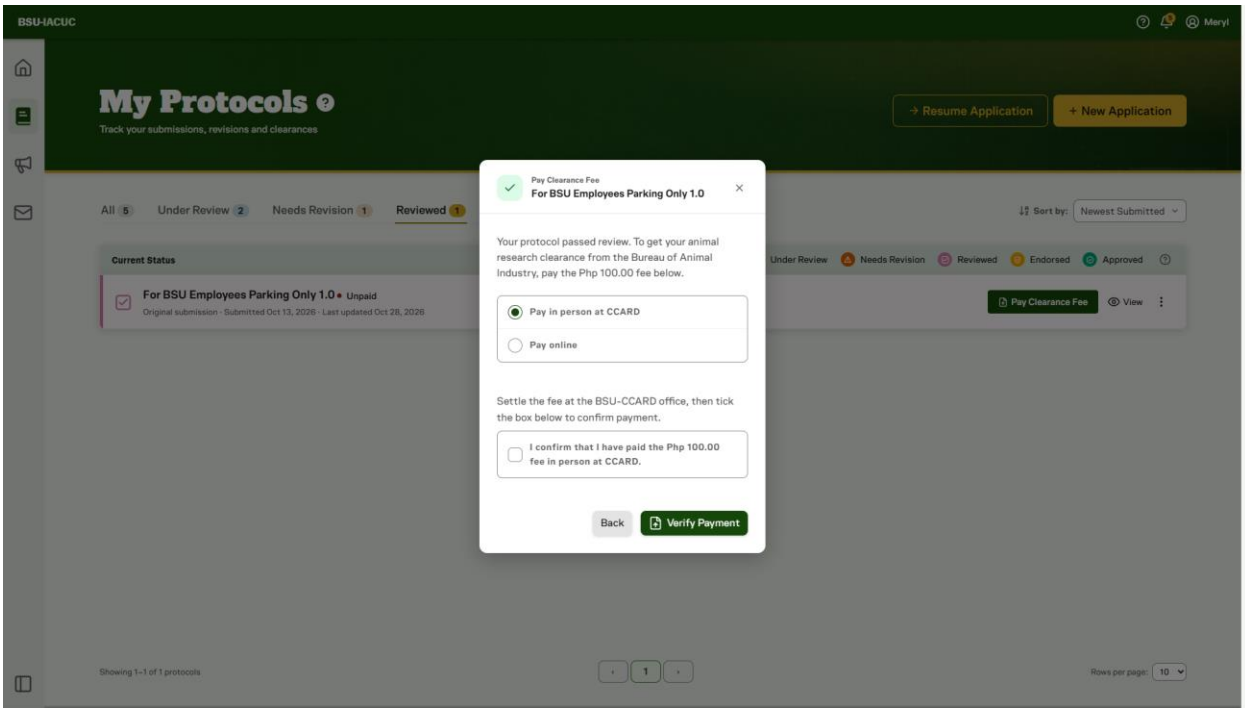
X. Paying the clearance fee

There is no fee for the IACUC review itself. The BAI charges Php 100.00 for the animal research clearance, paid after your protocol reaches Reviewed.

1. On the card, press Pay Clearance Fee.
2. Choose how you paid.
   - Pay in person at CCARD: settle the fee at the CCARD office, then tick the box that confirms you paid.
   - Pay online: press the link to contact the CCARD Director and arrange the payment. Afterward, upload a photo of your receipt, or of you handing over the payment (PDF or image, up to 10 MB).
3. Press Verify Payment.

Researchers from the BSU La Trinidad Campus and the BSU Secondary Laboratory School must pay in person. Other researchers may pay in person or online.

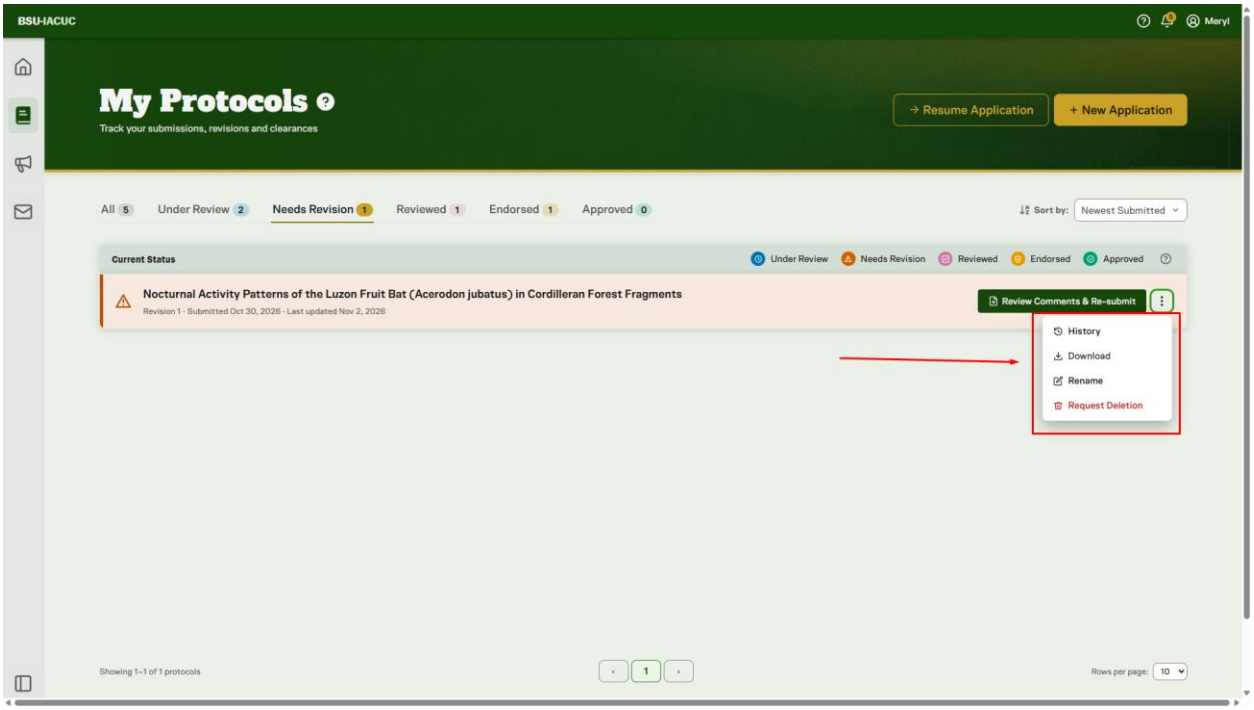
CCARD then checks your payment. A badge beside the title shows its state. If the payment is rejected, the card shows the reason, and the button changes to View rejection and resubmit so you can send new proof.



XI. The three-dot menu

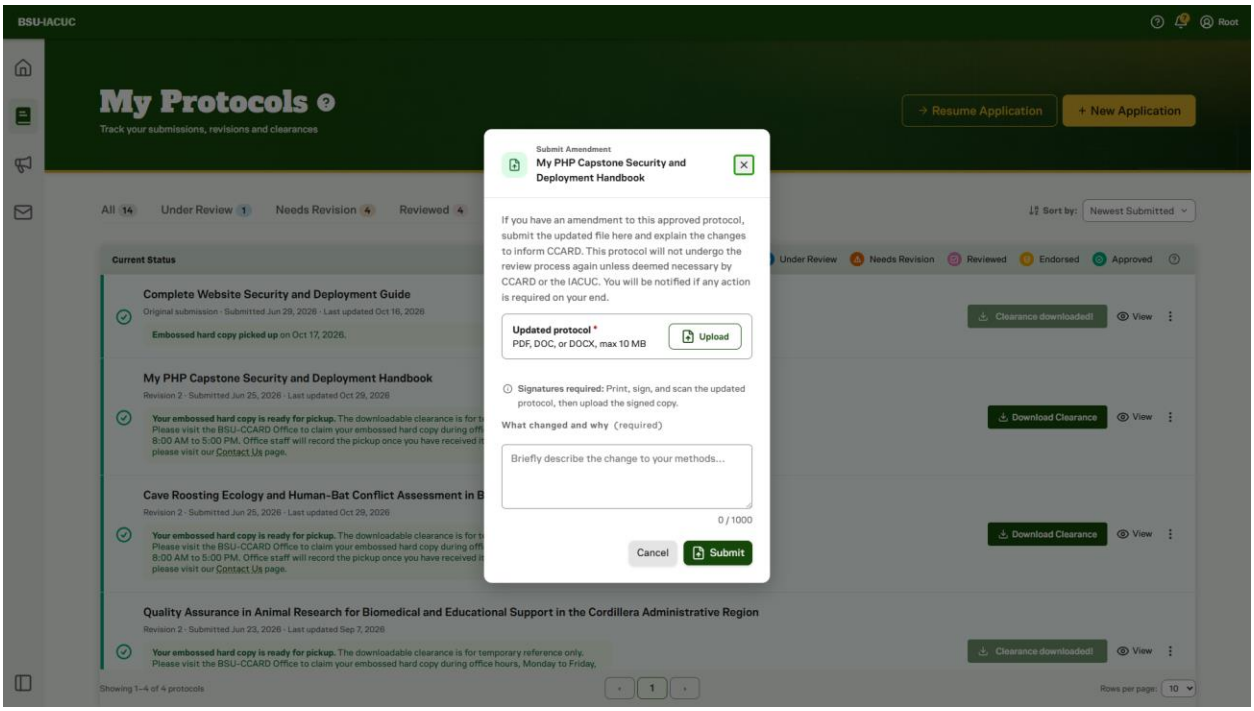
The three-dot button on each card, and the More button inside the viewer, open a menu. Only the items that apply to the protocol's status appear.

Item	*When it is available*	*What it does*
History	Always	Shows every submitted version, payment records, and earlier titles
Download	When a file is on record	Downloads the latest file
Rename	Under Review and Needs Revision	Changes the protocol title
Submit Amendment	Approved only	Sends an updated protocol to CCARD (see below)
Amendments	After you have submitted one	Lists your amendments
Request Deletion	Under Review, Needs Revision and Reviewed	Asks CCARD to delete the protocol
Cancel Deletion Request	While a request is pending	Withdraws the request



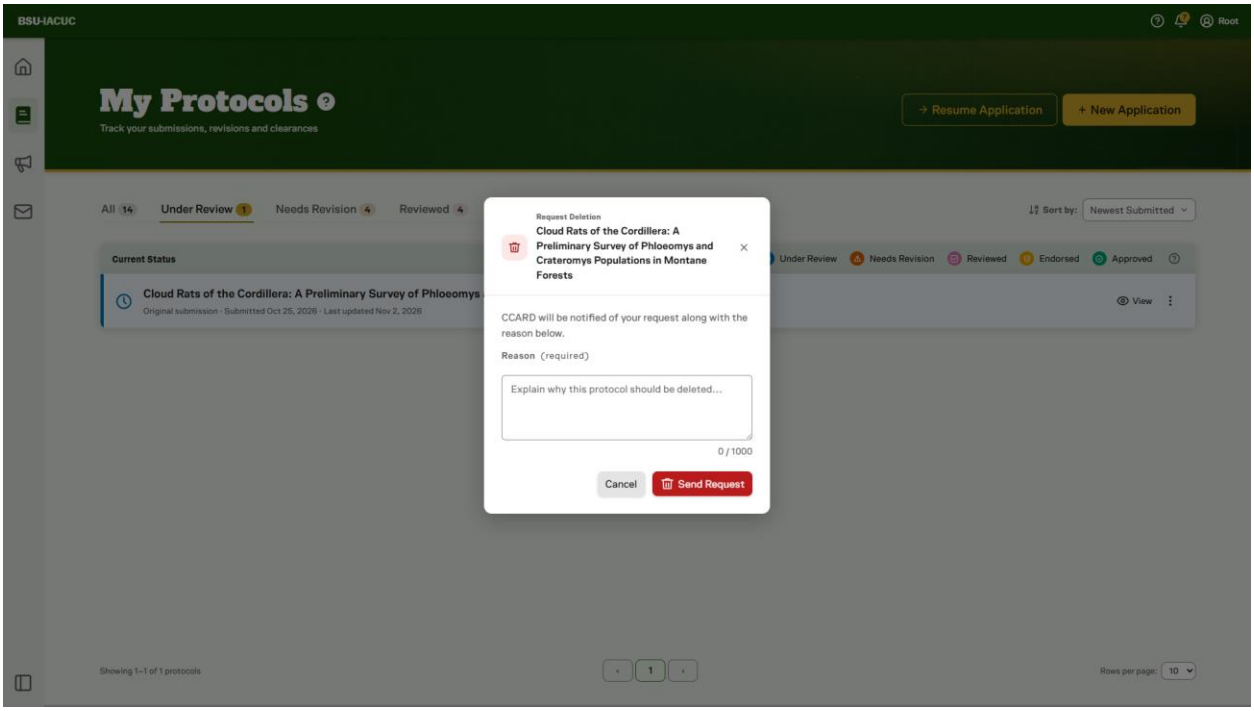
Submitting an amendment

Submit an amendment only if you must change something in your protocol after your clearance was issued. Upload the updated, signed protocol and describe what changed and why. The protocol is not reviewed again unless CCARD or the IACUC decides it should be, and you are notified if anything is needed from you. Even minor changes to procedures, personnel or animals must be sent through the portal.



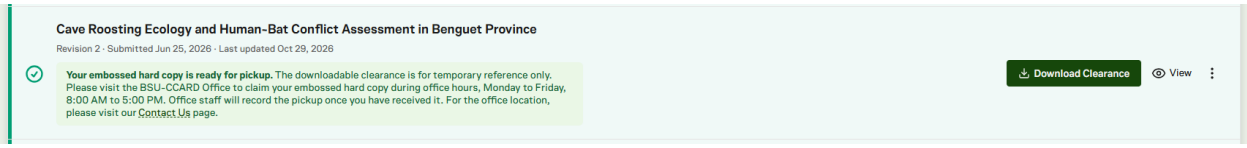
Requesting deletion

Deleting a protocol needs approval from CCARD. Enter your reason and confirm. CCARD can approve or reject the request. If it is rejected, you see the reason and the protocol stays as it is. A protocol that has already been endorsed or approved cannot be deleted.



XII. After approval

When the status changes to Approved, the card shows a Download Clearance button. Press it to save the soft copy of your animal research clearance. The soft copy is for temporary reference only. Visit the BSU-CCARD office to pick up the embossed hard copy. Once you have collected it, the card records the date.



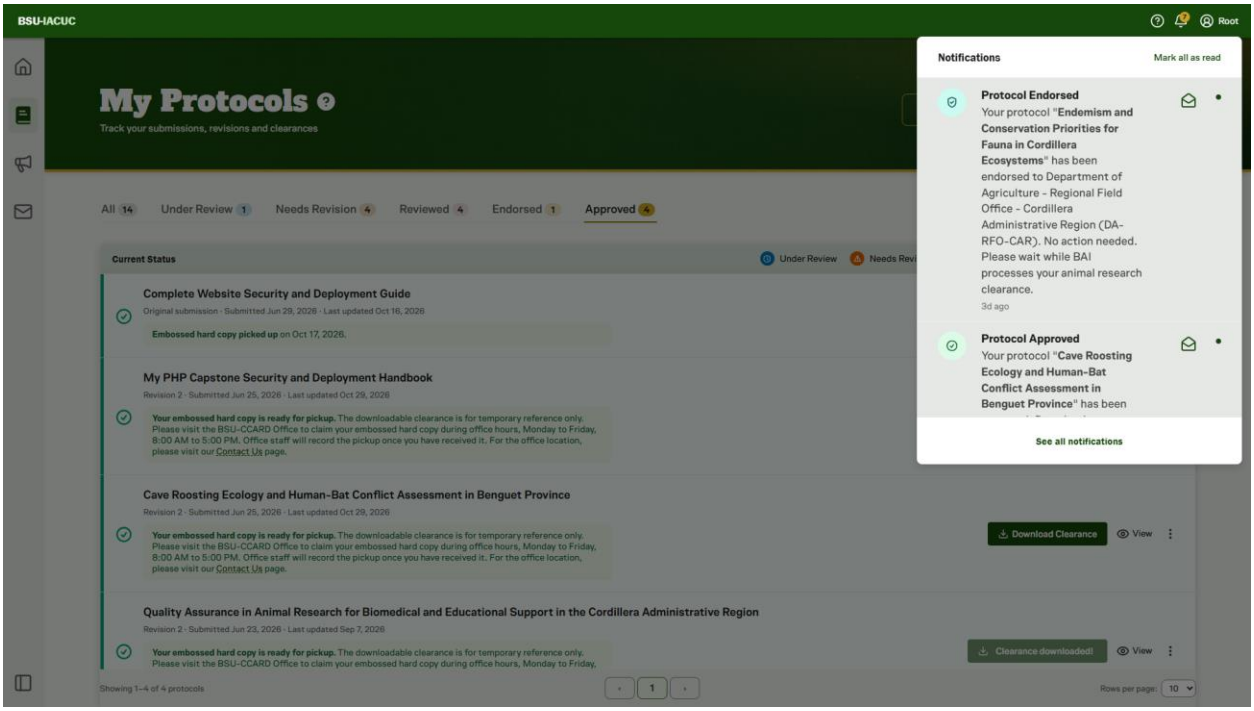
Your clearance has an end date. When it passes and none of your protocols are being processed, your account becomes inactive (see section IV).

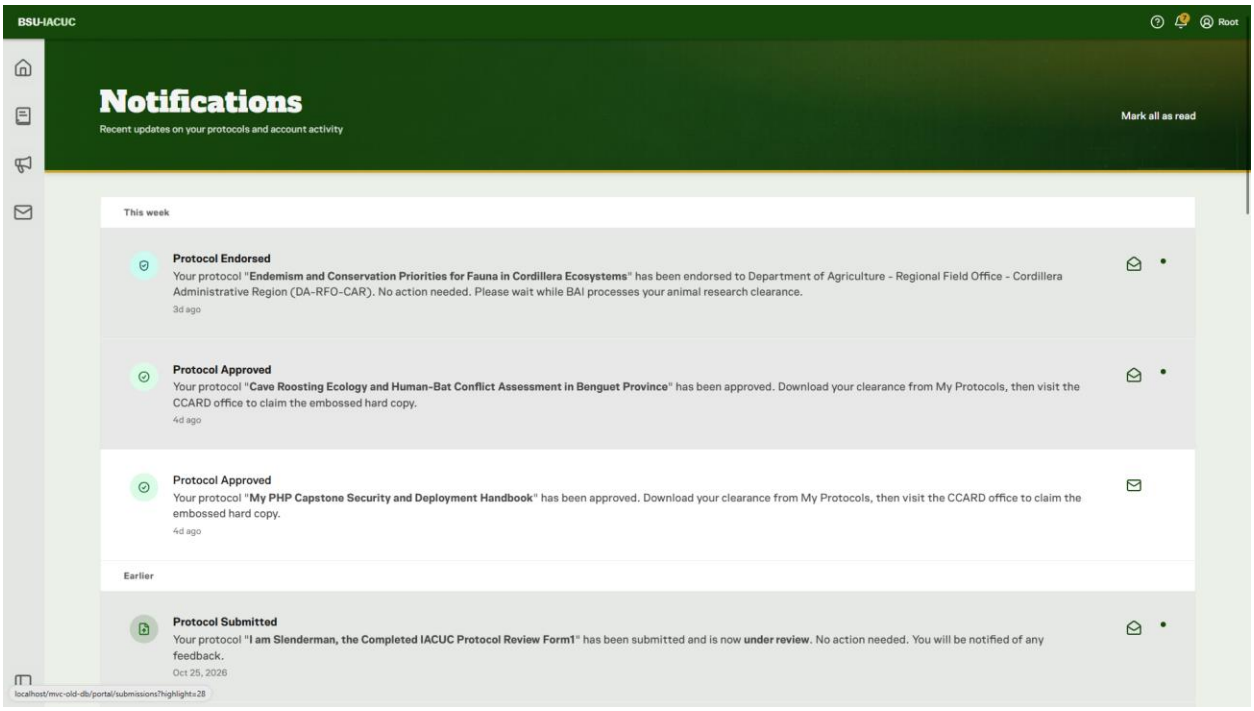
XIII. Notifications and email

The bell in the top bar shows a badge when there is something new. Press it to see the latest items, or choose See all notifications for the full list with page controls. Mark all as read clears the badge. Each notification says what happened and what, if anything, you need to do next.

The portal also sends emails for events such as submission received, status changes, feedback, payment results, certificate results and account changes. You can turn email updates on or off from My Account, or from the manage preferences link at the bottom of any email. Turning emails off does not stop in-portal notifications.

If the page shows a message that says new activity was detected, press it to refresh.





Working with a weak connection

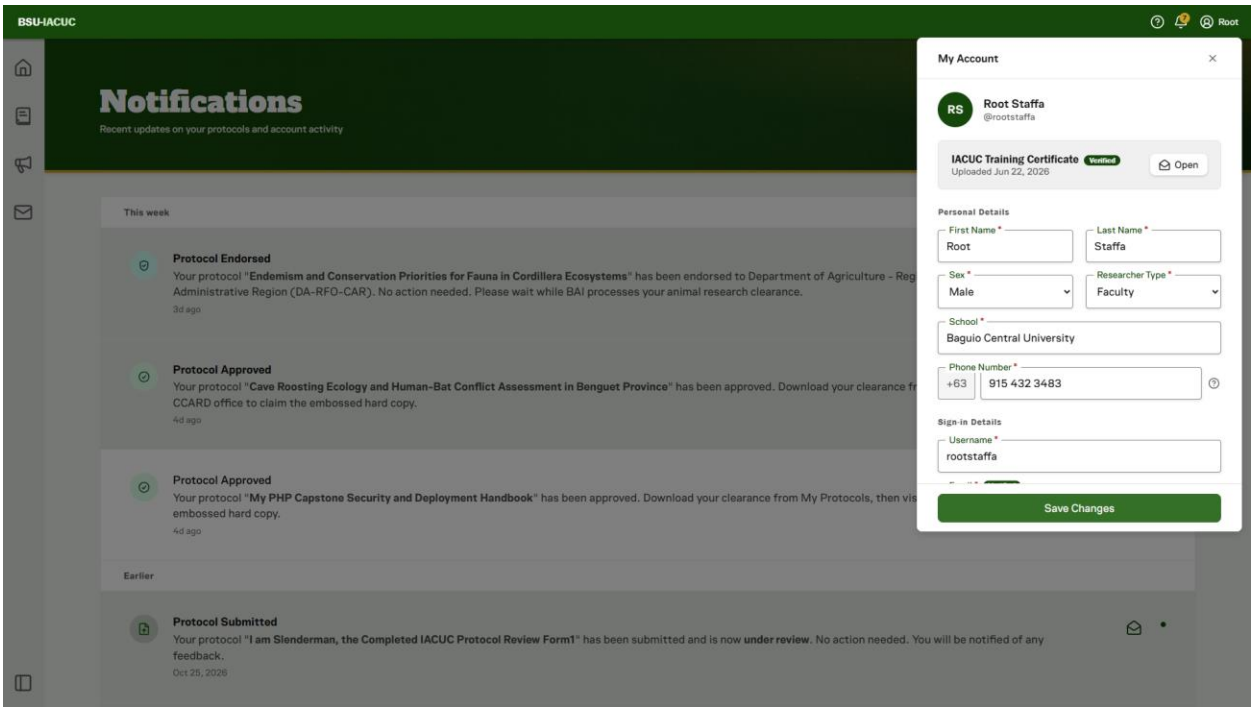
If your connection drops, an Offline tag appears beside the logo. Actions you take while offline are saved on your device and sent automatically when the connection returns. A banner shows what is waiting. Keep the page open until it finishes.

XIV. My Account

Open My Account from the top bar. Here you can:

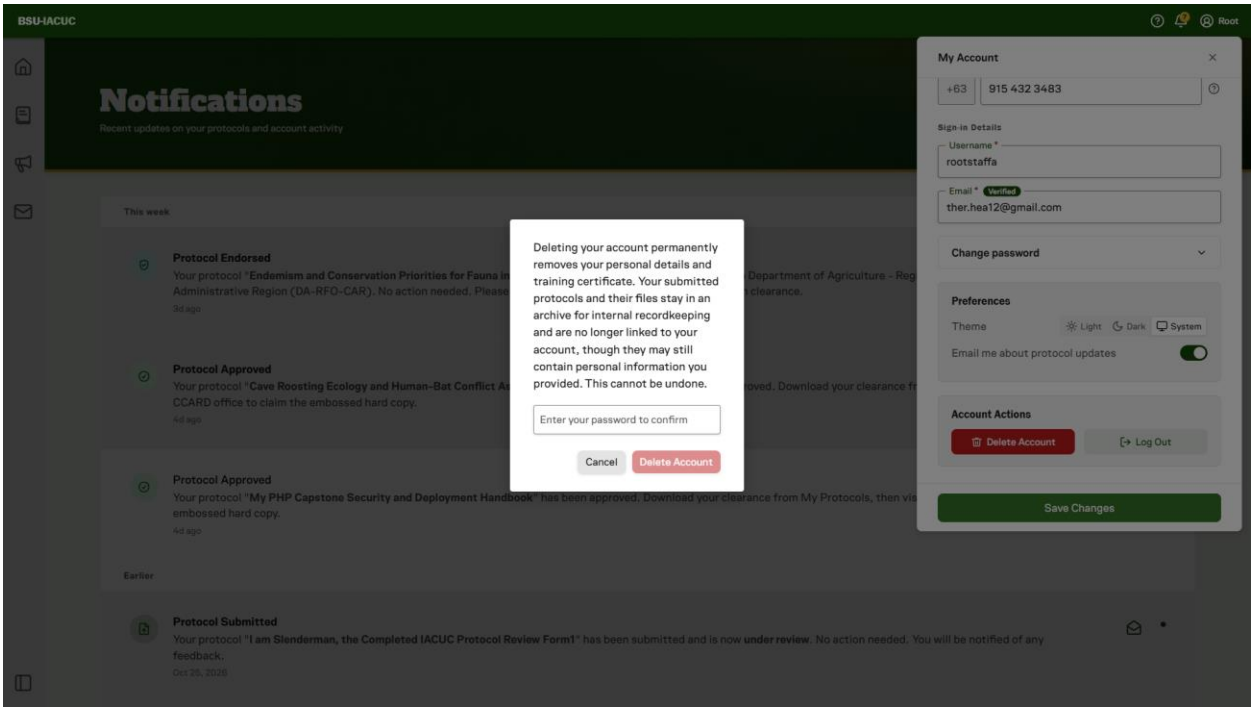
- Update your name, username, email, phone number, sex, researcher type and school.
- Change your password.
- See the status of your training certificate and upload a new one.
- Send yourself a new verification link if your email is not verified.
- Choose light, dark or system theme.
- Turn email notifications on or off.
- Delete your account.

If you registered before sex and researcher type were required, the portal will ask you to fill them in the next time you log in.



Deleting your account

Press Delete account and enter your password to confirm. You cannot delete your account while any of your protocols are still being processed. Approved protocols are kept in the records under the name Deleted User. Deletion cannot be undone.



XV. Troubleshooting

Problem	*What to try*
No verification email	Check spam, then request a new link from the login page
Cannot log in after several tries	Wait 15 minutes, or use Forgot Password
Reset link says invalid or expired	Request a new link from Forgot Password and use it right away
Cannot submit a new protocol	Check that your training certificate is Verified. If it was rejected, upload a new one
Upload is refused	Check the file type and keep it under 10 MB. Protocol files must be PDF, DOC or DOCX. Certificates and receipts must be PDF, JPG or PNG
Word file looks different after upload	Word files are converted to PDF. Use Preview, and upload a PDF yourself if the layout shifted
Cannot see reviewer comments	Comments appear only after the protocol has been returned for revision
Cannot delete my account	Wait until your protocols are no longer being processed
Signed out unexpectedly	The portal signs out after 30 minutes without activity. Log in again

XVI. Getting help

For questions about the IACUC, protocols or clearances, email ccard@bsu.edu.ph or use the Contact Us page, which lists every office, with address, phone, email and website. For problems with the portal itself, email the developers at meryl.arnobit@gmail.com or malipe.sheldon01@gmail.com.

XVII. Glossary

Term	*Meaning*
IACUC	Institutional Animal Care and Use Committee. Reviews research that uses live animals
CCARD	Cordillera Center for Animal Research and Development, Benguet State University
Protocol	The written plan for your animal work, on the official IACUC form
PI	Principal Investigator. The only person who may submit a protocol
Animal research clearance	The document issued through the BAI that allows your

	animal work to start
BAI	Bureau of Animal Industry
DA-RFO-CAR	Department of Agriculture, Regional Field Office, Cordillera Administrative Region
Amendment	A change to a protocol after its clearance was issued